

Disciplinary Committee regarding its match against Namdhari FC on January 13.

Kashi was awarded three points by the AIFF Disciplinary Committee after Namdhari was found to have fielded an ineligible player during that encounter, which the latter won 2-0. That decision was challenged and later stayed by the Appeals Committee, with the next hearing scheduled for April 28.

If it decides that the forfeiture stands, Kashi would move to 42 points and topple Churchill Brothers as the I-League champion of the 2024-25 season.

Churchill, meanwhile, had missed the opportunity to become the outright champion after its 1-1 draw against Real Kashmir.

"While the draw against Real Kashmir keeps Churchill Brothers at the top of the table, they must await the result of the AIFF Appeals Committee's hearing on the match between Namdhari FC and Inter Kashi (Match No. 45)," the AIFF said in its official report.

Inter Kashi remains confident of a positive verdict which would hand the club its maiden I-League title.

"We are very confident with our legal recourse, and we believe that we will get those three points. There was a reason why those points were initially awarded to us,"

Inter Kashi Director and Co-Founder Aryaman Shukla told *Sportstar*. "If the decision doesn't go in our favour, we as a team will take a call on how to move forward," Shukla added.

Meanwhile, in Srinagar, the Alemao family, owners of Churchill Brothers, celebrated in full vigour after the full-time whistle only to be informed that the club had 'provisionally' finished at the top of the table.

"If we became the champion, why were we not given the trophy then? We have to go with the law. If they had any confusion [Inter Kashi waiting for the three points in their match against Namdhari], why did they play the match yesterday?"

"The whole of India knows that Churchill Brothers is the champion but now they [Inter Kashi] are saying there is confusion. If the decision is pending in court (Appeals Committee), why play the game yesterday? That does not

interest me," Churchill Alemao said.

Before the final day encounters on April 6, Churchill needed only a point to win the league.

When asked about the Appeals Committee informing of their decision on April 28, which could see the title being snatched away from Churchill Brothers, Alemao claimed his club is a victim of manipulation.

"102 per cent I will not accept this decision... I know the system and law in football. FIFA rules say that if there is any confusion, then you should clear that and then play. If there is confusion, why have they [Kashi] not settled it? Now that we have become the champion, you're trying to fool us?"

While the AIFF Appeals Committee keeps both clubs hanging on a wire, Alemao said he even got a call from AIFF President Kalyan Chaubey, congratulating him after Churchill's draw against Kashmir. *Sportstar* reached out to

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Chaubey, but he was not available for comment.

Despite the cloud of confusion surrounding who will eventually be the I-League champion, Alemao said that according to the law his club is the champion and a big party was organised after the players landed in Goa.

It is yet to be seen whether a similar celebratory mood prevails in Goa on April 28 or whether it will shift towards Varanasi should the decision go in its favour.

Job not yet done: Inter Kashi players celebrate their win against Rajasthan United at the Kalyani Stadium in West Bengal. AIFF MEDIA